His long-term strategy was to expand the product range. To achieve this, he recruited fresh talent. As he wrote to JRD, he was able to ‘induce several competent people in technical and commercial areas to leave secure jobs … and to join NELCO’. New products were launched and there was an upswing in sales.

In the last quarter of 1971–72, the company came out of the red. But to sustain the momentum, the capital base of the company had to be expanded. On 25 January 1971, Ratan wrote to S.R. Vakil, J.D. Choksi, A.B. Bilimoria and P.M. Agerwala, who had ‘repeatedly assured’ him that ‘this aspect would be taken care of’. But support was not forthcoming. Ratan lamented to JRD that ‘for various reasons, certain Members of the TEC (Tata Electric Companies, now Tata Power) Board do not seem inclined to assist NELCO in a positive manner’.

Ratan was, however, determined to turn the company around. He adopted a two-pronged strategy—raise funds for NELCO and simultaneously appeal to JRD for the release of the promised funds. Moving on the former strategy, he took the unusual step of mortgaging the company’s office building to a lender, Sassoon J. David and Company Pvt. Ltd, and raised Rs 15 lakh.

Ratan reminded JRD once again that he had taken up the assignment on the assurance that funds would be made available to revive the company. His persistence paid off and NELCO finally received the promised assistance. He further raised funds through right issue, convertible and non-convertible scrips and other such measures. He also upgraded the company’s technological base through foreign collaborations. This equipped NELCO to provide services to other Tata companies, such as TISCO.

The slew of steps Ratan took resulted in the company growing at an average rate of 40 per cent for four straight years. It made profits in 1974–75. He had ‘turned it around without much support from the group and made it profitable,’ remarks Soonawala. But the declaration of Emergency in the country in 1975 suddenly hit the demand for radio sets and several other consumer products.

Yet, Ratan’s strategies kept the company afloat. After a visit to the NELCO factory in 1977, JRD acknowledged the contribution that Ratan had made in strengthening the company in a personal note that he sent the young Tata. He wrote: ‘I was much impressed by all I saw, and foresaw, and